

Politics

Politics is the process by which we decide who gets what, where, when and how. -- Geofry D. Wood

Politics is an authoritative allocation of values (resources). -- Robert A. Dahl

Politics is the process by which individual interests (desires, wants, etc.) are recognized with collective action and the provision of public goods.

Politics (from Greek: πολιτικός *politikos*, definition "of, for, or relating to citizens") is the process of making uniform decisions applying to all members of a group. It also involves the use of power by one person to affect the behavior of another person. More narrowly, it refers to achieving and exercising positions of governance — organized control over a human community, particularly a state. Furthermore, politics is the study or practice of the distribution of power and resources within a given community.

Word Root of POLITICS

The Greek word *polis*, meaning "city" or "community," and the related word *polītēs*, meaning "citizen," give us the roots polis and polites. Words from Greek *polis* and *polītēs* have something to do with cities or communities or the citizens who live in them. Politics is the science and art of governing citizens.

Politics

1. The science or art of political government.
2. The practice or profession of conducting political affairs.
3. Political affairs.
4. Political methods or maneuvers.
5. Political principles or opinions.
6. The use of strategy or intrigue in obtaining power, control, or status.

Simple Definition of POLITICS

1: the activities, actions, and policies that are used to gain and hold power in a government or to influence a government.

2: a person's opinions about the management of government *Hint: Politics can be used as a singular or a plural in writing and speaking. <Politics has always interested Me.> <The country's politics have changed.>*

Full Definition of POLITICS

1. a: the art or science of government
b: the art or science concerned with guiding or influencing governmental policy
c: the art or science concerned with winning and holding control over a government
2. Political actions, practices, or policies
3. a. Political affairs or business; *especially*: competition between competing interest groups or individuals for power and leadership (as in a government)

b : political life especially as a principal activity or profession
c : political activities characterized by artful and often dishonest practices

4: the political opinions or sympathies of a person

5. a : the total complex of relations between people living in society

b : relations or conduct in a particular area of experience especially as seen or dealt with from a political point of view <office politics> <ethnic politics>

The activities associated with the governance of a country or other area, especially the debate or conflict among individuals or parties having or hoping to achieve power.

Governance

What is Governance?

The complexity of governance is difficult to capture in a simple definition.

The need for governance exists anytime a group of people come together to accomplish an end. Though the governance literature proposes several definitions, most rest on three dimensions: authority, decision-making and accountability. At the Institute, our working definition of governance reflects these dimensions:

Governance determines who has power, who makes decisions, how other players make their voice heard and how account is rendered.

Ultimately, the application of good governance serves to realize organizational and societal goals.

The following examples help our understanding of each of the three dimensions of governance. Where a group is too large to efficiently make all necessary decisions, it creates an entity to facilitate the process.

- Group members delegate a large portion of the decision-making responsibility to this entity. In voluntary sector organizations this entity is the board of directors. In a public sector context this may be a board of directors, a committee or a project management team. One simple definition of governance is "the art of steering societies and organizations." Governance is about the more strategic aspects of steering, making the larger decisions about both direction and roles.

Some observers criticize this definition as being too simple. Steering suggests that governance is a straightforward process, akin to a steersman in a boat. These critics assert that governance is neither simple nor neat — by nature it may be messy, tentative, unpredictable and fluid. Governance is complicated by the fact that it involves multiple actors, not a single helmsman.

These multiple actors are the organization's stakeholders. They articulate their interests, influence how decisions are made, who the decision-makers are and what decisions are taken.

Decision-makers must absorb this input into the decision-making process. Decision-makers are then accountable to those same stakeholders for the organization's output and the process of producing it.

Governance is also a highly contextual concept. The process and practices that will apply will vary significantly given the environment in which they are applied. Governance in the public sector needs to take into account legal and constitutional accountability and responsibilities. In the non-governmental sector, representing stakeholder interests may be a determining factor in the governance to be applied. Even within these sectors, size, shape, form and function will vary greatly from one organization to the next. When working in the field of governance, one operates in an area where one size does not fit all.

UNDP: Five Principles of Good Governance

Defining the principles of good governance is difficult and controversial. The United Nations Development Program (UNDP) enunciates a set of principles that, with slight variations, appear in much of the literature. There is strong evidence that these UNDP-based principles have a claim to universal recognition. In grouping them under five broad themes, the Institute on Governance recognizes that these

principles often overlap or are conflicting at some point, that they play out in practice according to the actual social context, that applying such principles is complex and that they are all about not only the results of power but how well it is exercised.

Principles The UNDP Principles and related UNDP text on which they are based

Legitimacy and Voice	Participation – all men and women should have a voice in decision-making, either directly or through legitimate intermediate institutions that represent their intention. Such broad participation is built on freedom of association and speech, as well as capacities to participate constructively. Consensus orientation – good governance mediates differing interests to reach a broad consensus on what is in the best interest of the group and, where possible, on policies and procedures.
Direction	Strategic vision – leaders and the public have a broad and long-term perspective on good governance and human development, along with a sense of what is needed for such development. There is also an understanding of the historical, cultural and social complexities in which that perspective is grounded.
Performance	Responsiveness – institutions and processes try to serve all stakeholders. Effectiveness and efficiency – processes and institutions produce results that meet needs while making the best use of resources.
Accountability	Accountability – decision-makers in government, the private sector and civil society organizations are accountable to the public, as well as to institutional stakeholders. This accountability differs depending on the organizations and whether the decision is internal or external. Transparency – transparency is built on the free flow of information. Processes, institutions and information are directly accessible to those concerned with them, and enough information is provided to understand and monitor them.
Fairness	Equity – all men and women have opportunities to improve or maintain their well-being. Rule of Law – legal frameworks should be fair and enforced impartially, particularly the laws on human rights.

Governance and Government

1. Governance is traditionally associated with government. In literatures, they are often used interchangeably. But in the 1980s, political scientists broadened the meaning of governance as including, not just government actors, but also civil-society actors. Today, governance includes three sectors: the public sector (state actors and institutions), the private sector (households and companies), and the civil society (non-governmental organizations). These three sectors are said to work hand in hand in the process of governance. This new use of the term focuses on the role of “networks” in the achievement of the common good, whether these networks are intergovernmental, transnational, or international. In other words governance is broader than government in that other sectors are included in it.
2. Many authors also distinguish the two by associating government with “control and domination,” and governance with “decentralization and relational management.” On the one hand, government refers to a central institution which wields power over its subjects. It is the instrument patterned after the model of “command and control,” the government being in command over the affairs of the people. On the other hand, governance is closely associated with the concept of decentralization of power and the need for inter-sectoral management. Governance is based on the realization that the government cannot do

everything for the people, so that in order to survive the state should not only rely on government but also on the other sectors of the society.

3. Thus, under the current trend, there is a need to move from the "traditional hierarchical exercise of power by the government" to the new notion of a "dispersed and relational power in governance" – from government to governance. To govern should now mean to *facilitate* or *regulate*, not to dominate or command.

NATIONALISM

Definition of NATIONALISM

: A feeling that people have of being loyal to and proud of their country often with the belief that it is better and more important than other countries

: A desire by a large group of people (such as people who share the same culture, history, language, etc.) to form a separate and independent nation of their own.

Full Definition of NATIONALISM

A: loyalty and devotion to a nation; *especially* : a sense of national consciousness exalting one nation above all others and placing primary emphasis on promotion of its culture and interests as opposed to those of other national or supranational groups

B. National spirit or aspiration. 2. Devotion to the interests of one's own nation. 3. Desire for national advancement or independence for. 4. A movement as in the arts, based upon the folk idioms, history, aspirations, etc., of a nation. 5. An idiom or trait particular to a nation.

Nationalism is a shared group feeling in the significance of a geographical and sometimes demographic region seeking independence for its culture or ethnicity that holds that group together. This can be expressed as a belief or political ideology that involves an individual identifying with or becoming attached to one's nation. Nationalism involves national identity, by contrast with the related concept of patriotism, which involves the social conditioning and personal behaviors that support a state's decisions and actions.

Causes

Two major bodies of thought address the causes of nationalism:

1. the modernist perspective describes nationalism as a recent phenomenon that requires the structural conditions of modern society in order to exist
2. the primordialist perspective describes nationalism as a reflection of the ancient evolutionary tendency of humans to organize into distinct groupings based on an affinity of birth

Roser Masters in *The Nature of Politics* (1989) says that both the primordialist and modernist conceptions of nationalism involve an acceptance of three levels of common interest of individuals or groups in national identity

1. at an inter-group level, humans respond to competition or conflict by organizing into groups to either attack other groups or defend their group from hostile groups
2. at the intragroup level, individuals gain advantage through cooperation with others in securing collective goods that are not accessible through individual effort alone

3. on the individual level, self-interested concerns over personal fitness by individuals either consciously or subconsciously motivate the creation of group formation as a means of security

The behaviour of leadership groups or élites that involves efforts to advance their own fitness when they are involved in the mobilization of an ethnic or national group is crucial in the development of the culture of that group.

NATION—STATE

Simple Definition of NATION—STATE

: A form of political organization in which a group of people who share the same history, traditions, or language live in a particular area under one government

- A nation state is a type of state that cojoins the political entity of a state to the cultural entity of a nation, from which it aims to derive its political legitimacy to rule and potentially its status as a sovereign state if one accepts the declarative theory of statehood as opposed to the constitutive theory. A state is specifically a political and geopolitical entity, whilst a nation is a cultural and ethnic one. The term "nation state" implies that the two coincide, in that a state has chosen to adopt and endorse a specific cultural group as associated with it. "Nation state" formation can take place at different times in different parts of the world.
- The concept of a nation state can be compared and contrasted with that of the multinational state, city state, empire, confederation, and other state formations with which it may overlap. The key distinction is the identification of a people with a polity in the "nation state."

What is the Nation State?

When we talk about the nation state, we are really talking about three separate things: the nation, the state, and the nation state.

The nation state is a system of organization in which people with a common identity live inside a country with firm borders and a single government. But what does it all mean? The nation state has a dramatic influence on the way we live our lives. It's how we identify ourselves. I'm Bangladeshi. I'm American. I'm Russian. It also determines what language we speak, what laws we follow, and what holidays we celebrate. The nation state is a system of political, geographical, and cultural organization, and it is one of the most important parts of your life. The nation state is held together by its physical boundaries, its government, and the fact that the people believe they are connected to each other.

Bureaucracy

A bureaucracy (/bjuːˈrɒkrəsi/) is "a body of non-elective government officials" and/or "an administrative policy-making group". Historically, bureaucracy was government administration managed by departments staffed with non-elected officials. Today, bureaucracy is the administrative system governing any large institution.

The term "bureaucracy" is French in origin, and combines the French word *bureau* – desk or office – with the Greek word κράτος *kratos* – rule or political power.

It was coined in the mid-18th century by the French economist Jacques Claude Marie Vincent de Gournay, and was a satirical pejorative from the outset. Gournay never wrote the term down, but was later quoted at length in a letter from a contemporary:

The first known English-language use dates to 1818.^[17] Here, too, the sense was pejorative, with Irish novelist Lady Morgan referring to "the Bureaucratie, or office tyranny, by which Ireland has so long been governed.

By the mid-19th century, the word was being used in a more neutral sense, referring to a system of public administration in which offices were held by unelected career officials. In this sense "bureaucracy" was seen as a distinct form of management, often subservient to a monarchy. In the 1920s, the definition was expanded by the German sociologist Max Weber to include any system of administration conducted by trained professionals according to fixed rules. Weber saw the bureaucracy as a relatively positive development; however by 1944, the Austrian economist Ludwig von Mises noted that the term bureaucracy was "always applied with an opprobrious connotation, and by 1957 the American sociologist Robert Merton noted that the term "bureaucrat" had become an epithet.

Power

What is Power?
Power is the ability to command obedience from others using force or influence. It is the capacity to affect another person's behavior by the threat of sanction. The sanction may be negative or positive. Therefore, a political leader may have the ability to control the actions of others by promising those who support him wealth or honour, or he may threaten to deny such rewards to those who oppose him. Sanctions are used if there is no compliance.

Forms of power
(1) Political power: The elected president or prime minister of a state possesses political power. It is the power derived from the people and the constitution.

(2) Economic power: This refers to power possessed by someone having great wealth and resources.

(3) Physical power: This refers to the application of force and physical/muscular strength in compelling obedience. This may result to discomfort.

(4) Military power: This refers to the armed forces such as the Army, Navy and the Air Force. They have the power of arms and ammunition, and control the instruments of violence in a country.

Sources of political power

(1) The constitution: the constitution is the source of political power for those occupying positions of government. It specifies how power should be acquired and how it should be exercised.

(2) Through coercion: Power may be acquired through the use of force or coercion. The military power is a power of coercion. Coup d' etat is a typical example of coercion.

(3) Through Charisma: Charisma such as eloquence, cleverness, intelligence, etc can also be a source of power and influence on other people. Many have used the power of oratory to gain a large crowd to follow them e.g. Martin Luther King, Bola Ige, Tunde Bakare, Obafemi Awolowo, etc.

(4) Through Economic resources: Money, wealth, asset or property can be a good source of power used by its owner to influence other people and to gain followership.

(5) Through Inheritance: This refers to heredity as a source of power. Heredity is the right or power acquired by natural birth into kingship or royal family.

Authority

What is Authority?

Authority is the formal or legal right conferred on a person or a group of persons to make and enforce laws or policies which the citizens obey. Authority is the right to rule conferred by the constitution and people on a person or representative of the people.

Authority is the quality of being able to get people to do things because they think the individual or group has the right to tell them what to do. In effect, those in authority are followed because it is believed that they fulfill a need within the community or political system. Authority, then, is linked to respect, which creates legitimacy and therefore leads to power.

Legitimate power or influence is generally called authority. It is power clothed with legitimacy. It is the authentic form of power based on consent, voluntary obedience and persuasion.

Types of Authority

- (1) Traditional Authority: This is found in our traditional societies in which the traditional leaders, chiefs or council of elders exercise authority based on customs and traditions of the land.
- (2) Charismatic Authority: This is the authority derived from the belief in the exceptional ability of a leader which inspires allegiance and loyalty among the followers.
- (3) Legal/Rational Authority: This is the authority derived from the constitution of a modern democratic state, exercised through the three organs of government.
- (4) Delegated Authority: This is the authority given to someone to exercise functions and carry out certain responsibility on specific areas on behalf of others.
- (5) Technical Authority: It is based on the level of expertise the individual has acquired on the job. This kind of authority has to be respected, recognized and accepted in that particular area concerned.

Legitimacy

What is Legitimacy?

Legitimacy is anything that is acceptable or allowed by law. Legitimacy is a political term which refers to the acceptance and recognition by the citizens of a country, the rights of their rulers to govern. A government is considered legitimate if it comes to power through constitutional means. Elected governments are legitimate. However, some people believe that a military government can acquire the status of being legitimate through popular government policies.

Factors that determine legitimacy

- (1) Free and fair election: A periodic election that is both free and fair will make a government legitimate. It is a major evidence of the support of the people to the government.
- (2) Good Governance: A government that rules well and provides for the people lacking social amenities, infrastructure and service will earn the people's support and enjoy legitimacy.
- (3) Reliable and responsive leadership: The leadership style of a leader in terms of its reliability and responsiveness to the people's voice and opinions will go a long in earning the leader legitimacy.
- (4) Custom and tradition: Respect for the existing customs and tradition of the society by a leader can determine whether a leader enjoys legitimacy or not.
- (5) Foreign policy objectives: Other countries of the world will also lend their support and co-operation to a government that has favourable and accommodating foreign policy objectives.
- (6) Level of Political participation: The extent to which a government involves all sections of the people in governance also determines the amount of legitimacy it enjoys.
- (7) Ideological beliefs: A government that will enjoy legitimacy must also uphold the ideological beliefs and tenets of the country e.g. Liberalism in USA and Conservatism in the UK.
- (8) Freedom of the press: The level of freedom government grants the media in carrying out their duties in circulating information and serving as watchdogs will also inform the people about the status of the government.
- (9) Rule of law: The position of a government to the rulings of the law as perceived by the people also informs their judgment of the government and the level of legitimacy they give to the government.

Sovereignty

What is Sovereignty?

Sovereignty is the power that an independent country has to govern itself without any form of interference or intrusion. It is the power of supremacy that a truly independent nation enjoys. It is the supreme power and authority of the state over its citizens and operations. It is the power of the state to make laws and enforce them with all the means of coercion it cares to use without any interference by other states.

The idea of sovereignty originated from a French philosopher and political thinker Jean Bodin (1530 – 1590).

Types of Sovereignty

The following are the different types of sovereignty:

- (1) Internal Sovereignty: This refers to the supreme power the state has to make and enforce laws within its areas of authority.

(2) External Sovereignty: This refers to the power of the state to exist and to conduct its domestic affairs without external interference. It is the power of the state to decide how to relate with other nations of the world.

Location of Sovereignty in a state

(1) Federal state: Sovereignty, in a federal state, is located in the constitution which is supreme and the authorities which the constitution recognises e.g the central/federal government and the states and local government respectively.

(2) Unitary state: Sovereignty in a unitary state resides with the central government. The central government is supreme.

(3) The monarch: In some nations of the world, sovereignty resides with the monarch i.e. the King or Queen. A typical example is the Queen in Britain.

(4) Military regime: Military regime has a way of centralizing power, thereby concentrating power at the central government.

Limitations to the Sovereignty of a state

(1) The constitution: It spells out the boundaries of power for those in authority and defines the limit of powers to be exercised by the various levels of government.

(2) The electorate: The electorates possess ultimate power through election. This makes the government to be responsible to the people.

(3) Public opinion: Opinions of people are taken into consideration when formulating policies. This in a way is a limitation to the exercise of their powers.

(4) International organisations: international organisations like the U.N.O., O.A.U require their members to abide by their charter and all collective decisions. This is also a form of limitation to the members' state sovereignty.

(5) Military intervention: The military's forceful removal of democratic government is a limitation to the sovereignty of the state.

(6) International financial institution: Institutions like the World Bank and the IMF dictate to many countries on how to run their economies.

(7) Customs and traditions: Customs and tradition of the people are often considered by the state before or when making laws.

(8) Civil unrest and war: These are often a major threat to the internal sovereignty of the state. The supreme authority of the state is often subjugated during civil unrest and war.

DEMOCRACY

A: government by the people; *especially*: rule of the majority

B: a government in which the supreme power is vested in the people and exercised by them directly or indirectly through a system of representation usually involving periodically held free election.

Democracy: Form of government, where a constitution guarantees basic personal and political rights, fair and free elections, and independent courts of law.

Democracy: Kinds, Basic Principles

The term democracy is derived from the Greek word *demos* and *kratos*, the former meaning 'the people' and the latter 'power'. Democracy thus means 'power of the people'.

Definitions of Democracy

1. Democracy, according to the Greeks, is the Government in which people rule over themselves. Aristotle (384-322BC) considered it as a perverted form of government. Herodotus (483-425BC) says, the democracy denotes that form of government in which the ruling power of the state is largely vested in the members of the community as a whole.
2. In the words of President Abraham Lincoln (1809-1865), democracy is a government of the people, by the people and for the people.
3. According to Bryce, "Democracy is that form of Government in which the ruling power of a state is legally vested, not in any particular class or classes but in the members of the community as a whole".
4. "Democracy", writes Mazzini "is the government of the best and wisest, for the progress of all and through all".
5. Prof. Seeley says, "Democracy is a government in which everybody has a share".
6. According to Dicey, "Democracy is a form of government in which the governing body is a comparatively large fraction of the entire nation".
7. Professor A.B. Hall, in his work on "Popular Government", defines democracy as "popular government in the last analysis and for all practical purposes as being that form of political organization in which public opinion has control".
8. According to Gettell, "Democracy is that form of government in which the mass of the population possesses the right to share in the exercise of sovereign power".

THE PILLARS OF DEMOCRACY

- Sovereignty of the people.
- Government based upon consent of the governed.
- Majority rule.
- Minority rights.
- Guarantee of basic human rights.
- Free and fair elections.
- Equality before the law.
- Due process of law.
- Constitutional limits on government.